# Your case preparation checklist

Print this page. Keep it beside the case as you prepare, and bring it with your notes.

## Read with a purpose

- ☐ **Check the assignment.** Read your instructor's questions and instructions. Use them to focus your preparation.
- ☐ **Get the whole situation.** Preview the opening, ending, headings, and exhibits. Then read the case. Note who is involved, what is at stake, and why action may be needed.
- ☐ **Write the main question.** Are you choosing an action, explaining a problem, or judging a result? Write the question your analysis needs to answer.

## Analyze and make useful notes

- ☐ **Reread for evidence.** Study the passages and exhibits that answer your question, one issue at a time. Separate facts from interpretations and assumptions. Look for evidence against your first view.
- ☐ **Apply course ideas.** Use a relevant concept, theory, or framework to explain the evidence. Show how it helps and where it falls short. A framework name alone is not analysis.
- ☐ **Work through the numbers.** Calculate what matters to the question. Check units, comparisons, and assumptions. Write what each result means and what it cannot establish.
- ☐ **Compare and choose.** Judge alternatives by the same criteria. Explain your main trade-off, the strongest objection, and what would change your view. For a decision, identify a first action.
- ☐ **Keep notes you can use.** Record your position, supporting evidence with page or exhibit references, key calculations, and unresolved questions. Write reasons in your own words instead of copying the case.

## Before class

- ☐ **Discuss with your teammates.** Prepare on your own first, then meet before class when collaboration is allowed. Compare reasoning and challenge assumptions. You do not need to agree on one answer.
- ☐ **Practise a short opening.** State your position, strongest evidence, and an important uncertainty. Be ready to explain your reasoning and ask a useful question. Avoid memorizing a speech.

## During and after class

- ☐ **Listen and build on others.** Answer the question being discussed. Connect your comment to what others said. Challenge ideas respectfully and revise when warranted. Take brief notes so you can keep listening.
- ☐ **Review what you learned.** After class, record what changed in your thinking and why. Note a course idea you understand better, its limits, and how you could use it in another case.

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Independent handout by Kamyar Goudarzi, based on this exercise and William Ellet, The Case Study Handbook: A Student's Guide, revised edition, Harvard Business Review Press, 2018, chapters 3 and 7. Not a Harvard publication.